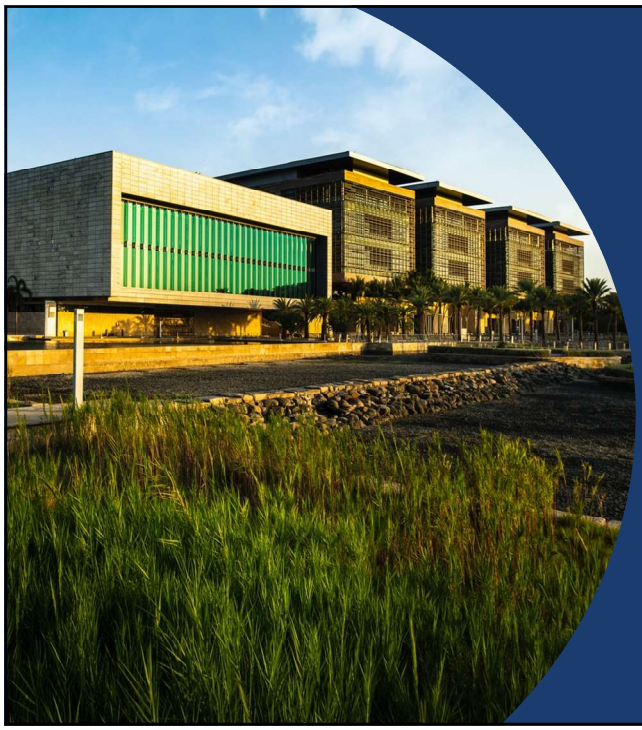

جامعة الملك عبدالله للعلوم والتقنية
King Abdullah University of Science and Technology

KSA UNIVERSITIES

DEVELOPING ACADEMIC LEADERS PROGRAM

Leading the Delivery of Academic Change, Global Connections & Leading the Social Purpose of HE

Professor Jonathan Grant
Dr Tom Kennie, &
Dr Sara Hurley

1

ACADEMIC LEADERSHIP FRAMEWORK

Six Core Capabilities
At the heart of effective deanship:

Leading Self
Understanding your leadership strengths and preferences

Surrounding capabilities:
- ***Leading Academics***
- ***Leading Academic Teams***
- ***Leading Strategically***
- ***Leading Academic Change***
- ***Leading Social Impact***

Each capability builds on self-awareness and strengthens your overall leadership effectiveness

| 2

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DAY 4 – THURSDAY 2nd APRIL (am)

جامعة الملك عبدالله للعلوم والتقنية
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01 Introduction

02 Leading Academic Change

03 Break Out Discussion – Case Study

04 Feedback and Some Conceptual Models

05 Leading Change– Case Studies

06 Address from the Minister

06 LUNCH

3

DAY 4 – THURSDAY 2nd APRIL(pm)

جامعة الملك عبدالله للعلوم والتقنية
King Abdullah University of Science and Technology

07 Global Connections – UK-KSA

08 BREAK

09 Reflecting on the Key Learning Points

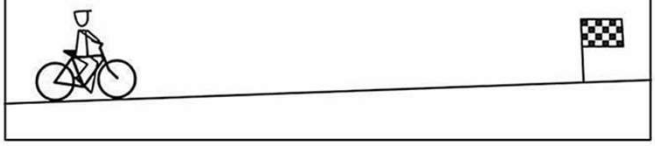
10 Next Steps

11 DINNER

4

Leading Academic Change

The Plan



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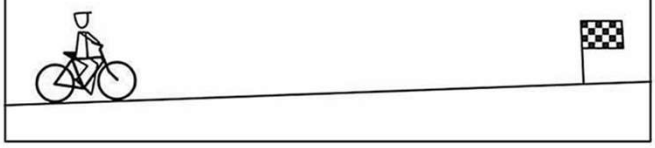
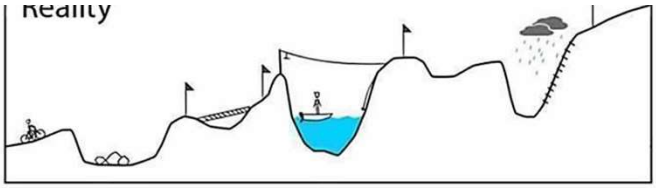
Leading Academic Change

The Plan



Its simple, all you need is a plan,



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LEADING ARTEMIS II AND LEADING ACADEMIC CHANGE?
FROM THE 'LAUNCH PAD' PLAN TO 'LIFT OFF'

| 7

7

AREAS OF FOCUS

Clarifying and coordinating your collective agenda for 2026 to achieve 'lift-off'

Strategic Focus

Internal Focus ***External Focus***

Operational Focus

| 8

8

Case Study

Share the advice you would offer Fatima as the Director of the new Institute

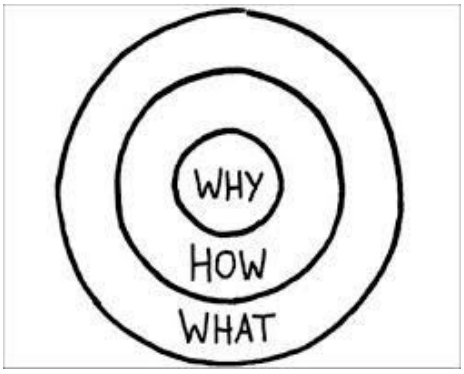
9

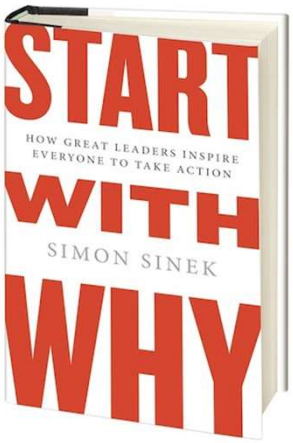
Actions

- **Setting/Co-setting Expectations (with the change project Sponsor)**
- **Settle your understanding of the answer to the questions *Why?*, why now, why this structure?**

10

The Golden Circle – START with *WHY*





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Actions

- **S**etting/Co-setting Expectations (with the change project **S**ponsor)
- **S**ettle your understanding of the answer to the questions *Why?*, why now, why this structure
- **S**trategy – decide what to do but as important think through how to develop your **S**hared **S**trategic agenda.

12

4-D APPRECIATIVE INQUIRY CHANGE MODEL

DESTINY

What measures should we use to monitor our progress and shape our destiny?

DISCOVERY

Engagement to recognise 'the best of what has been and what is'

DESIGN

Defining the organisational design which will accelerate the achievement of the dream

DREAM

Creating clear and ambitious statements of higher purpose and ambition – defining 'what could we become'?

(adapted from Cooerrider and Whitney, 2005)

13

Developing a Strategy
Some Options and Consequences

What are the pros and cons of the various options?
Under what conditions would each be appropriate?
In the circumstances which would you recommend?

	Do it herself	Work Jointly with a facilitator	Use an External Consultant
Fatima's vision	*Probably too early*	*If developed after workshop*	*Potential implementation problems*
Review some scenarios	*Potentially useful*	*More useful starting point*	*Potential ownership problems*
Free ranging discussion	*High risk of derailment*	*Of potential value if handled by facilitator*	*Potentially chaotic*

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Actions

- Setting/Co-setting Expectations (with the change project Sponsor)
- Settle your understanding of the answer to the questions *Why?*, why now, why this structure
- Strategy – decide what to do but as important think through how to develop your Shared Strategic agenda.
- Seek gaps in delivery and take action

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Seek Gaps in Delivery and Take Action

Vision	Skills	Incentives	Resources	Action Plan	=	Success
Vision	Skills	Incentives	Resources	Missing	=	False Starts
Vision	Skills	Incentives	Missing	Action Plan	=	Frustration
Vision	Skills	Missing	Resources	Action Plan	=	Resistance
Vision	Missing	Incentives	Resources	Action Plan	=	Anxiety
Missing	Skills	Incentives	Resources	Action Plan	=	Confusion

Adapted from Knoster, T. (1991) Presentation in TASH Conference. Washington, D.C. Adapted by Knoster from Enterprise Group, Ltd.

16

Actions

- Setting/Co-setting Expectations (with the change project Sponsor)
- Settle your understanding of the answer to the questions *Why?*, why now, why this structure
- Strategy – decide what to do but as important think through how to develop your Shared Strategic agenda.
- Seek gaps in delivery and take action
- Stay adaptive as the change(s) unfold

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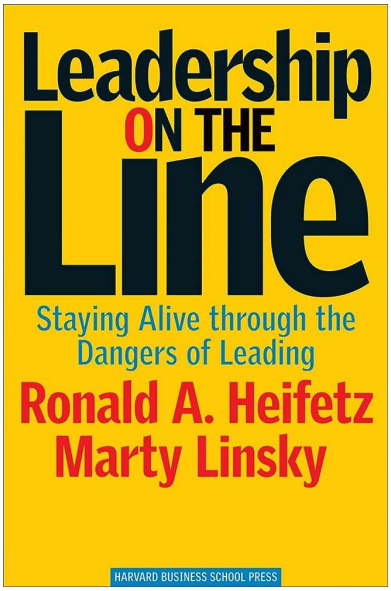

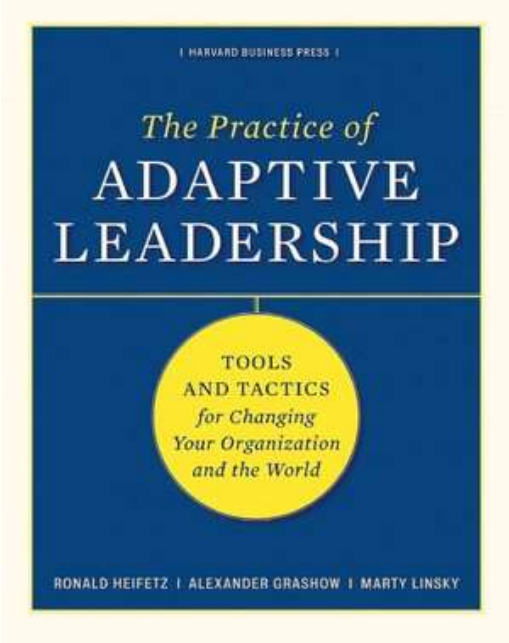

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Source: Heifetz & Linsky: Leadership on the Line, 2002

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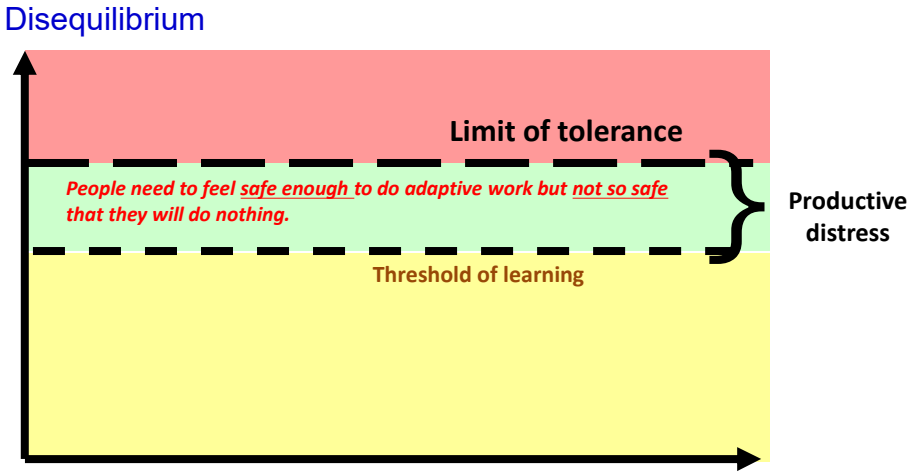
Productive *distress*



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‘Get on the balcony’

- Gain a holistic perspective
- Systems thinking
- Technical vs. Adaptive Work
- Simultaneously on the dance floor and above it on the balcony
- Observe patterns and people

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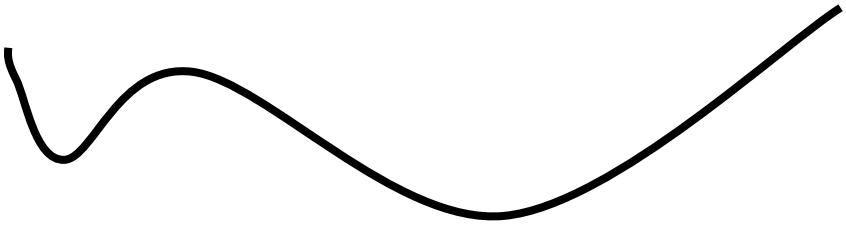
The Transition Change Curve



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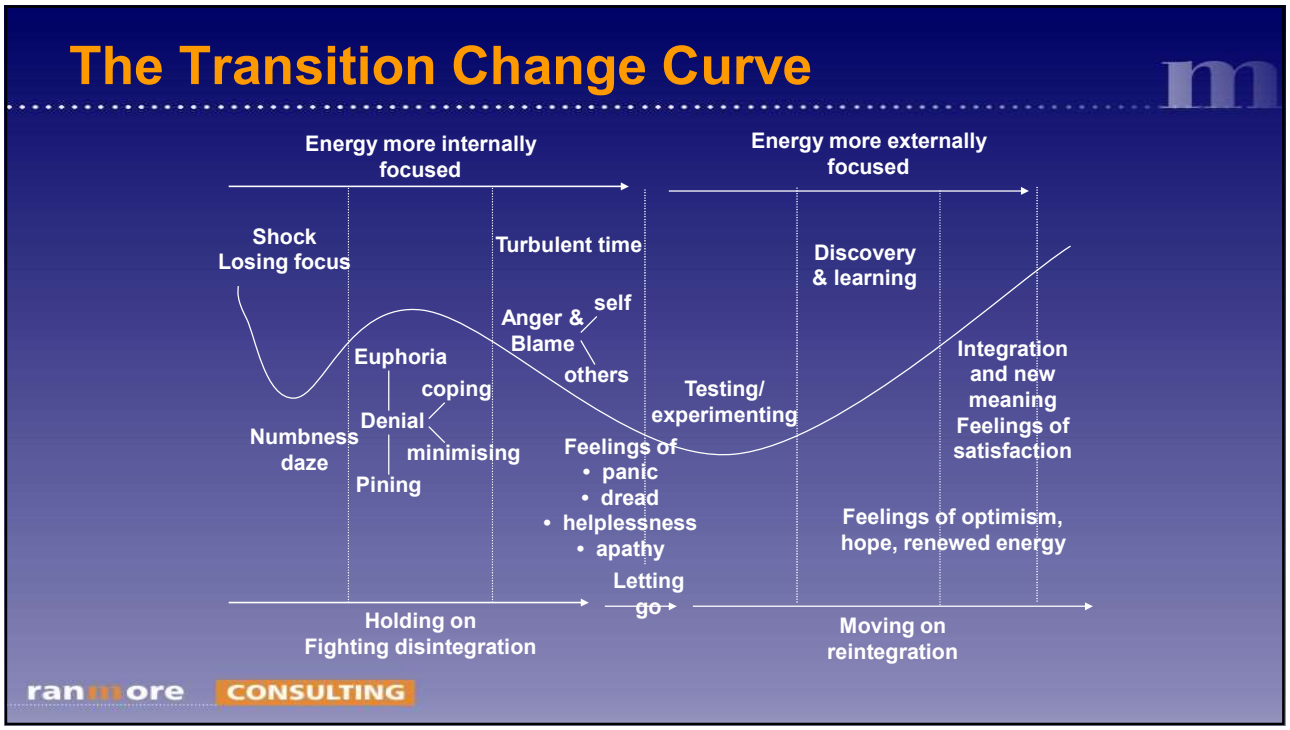

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'Think Politically'

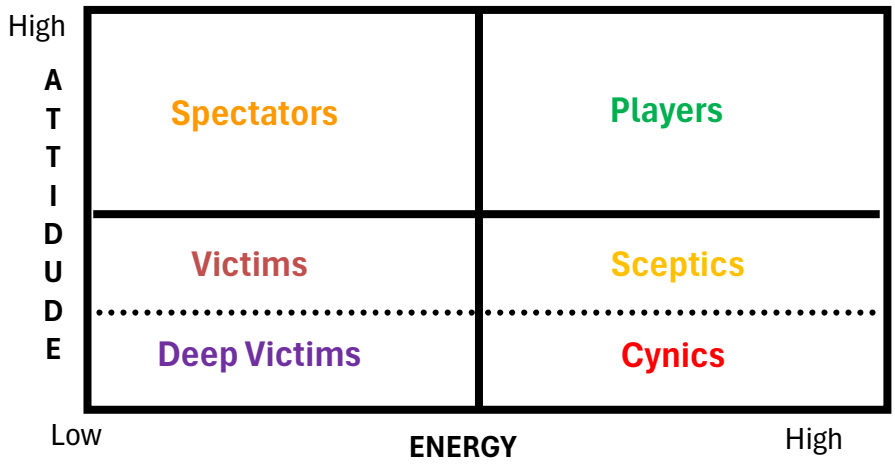
- Encourage supporters
- Stay close to opponents
- Court the undecided
- Acknowledge the loss- uncertainty, disloyalty, and incompetence- change brings
- Allow time for transition but leave behind those that cannot make the change

24

‘Think Politically’

How do each group feel? How do they react? What do they need?

How do you influence them?



(Edmonstone, 2003)

25

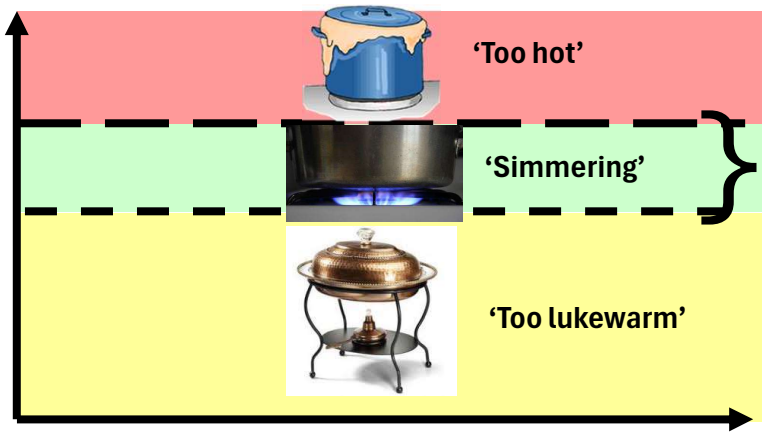
‘Orchestrate the Process’

- **Establish a safe holding environment, like a pressure cooker**
- **Moderate temperature to pace work progress**
- **Let issues ripen when needed**
- **Balance pain of loss with positive possibility of change for their future**
- **Don’t take personal attacks personally**

26

Getting the temperature right

Disequilibrium



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'Hold Steady'

- Take the heat
- Patiently let issues ripen
- Focus attention on the issues
- Ask lots of real tough questions
- Suspend your reality
- Encourage risk and experimentation

28

‘Anchor Yourself’

- Don’t confuse one’s self with one’s professional role
- Identify a truly trustworthy confidant who can really tell you what you need to hear
- Do not use allies as confidants
- Find a sanctuary for retreat, rejuvenation, and personal reflection

29

What characterises *less constructive* from *very constructive* conversations?

- Dominated by 1
- I’m right, you’re wrong
- Closed perspective
- Unconscious bias
- About early judgement
- Avoids feelings
- Exaggerates differences
- Wrong time, wrong place
- Does not express needs
- ‘Fake’ & Confrontational
- Ends on a –ve
- …..

- Dialogue between 2
- Mutual understanding
- Open and curious
- Conscious of bias
- Suspending judgement
- Expresses feelings
- Seeks common ground
- Right time, right place
- Expresses needs
- Authentic & Empathetic
- Ends on a +ve
- ……

30

Diagnose: What *Really* is the Problem?

- Is it a motivational issue?
- Is it a skills issue?
- Is it a lack of job clarity?
- Is it a lack of clear standards?
- Is it a structural or 'boundary management' issue?
- Is it a cultural issue?
- Is it a lack of compatibility
- issue?

- Is it a workload issue?
- Is it also a political issue?
- Is it a legal issue?
- …..
- AND
- Who else has a part to play in the performance issue?
- Who else is part of the problem?
- Am I part of the problem?

31

Would a framework help in some cases? Engaging BRAIN

I'd like to offer you some reflections about ….

….is that OK?

- B – because…. explain Benefit to the *recipient* of the feedback
- R - what *I've* noticed and would like to Reflect back is …….
- A – Could there be another reason for what I've observed?
- I - the Impact of what you do is ……
- N - what might you consider doing next time this situation arises? ……

32

‘Retain Your Humanity’

Quality of Heart	Becomes	Dressed Up As:
Innocence	Cynicism	Realism
Curiosity	Arrogance	Authoritative Knowledge
Compassion	Callousness	The “thick skin” of experience

33

Adaptive Leadership Strategies

- Get on the balcony

- Think politically

- Orchestrate the process

- Hold steady

- Anchor yourself

Retain your humanity

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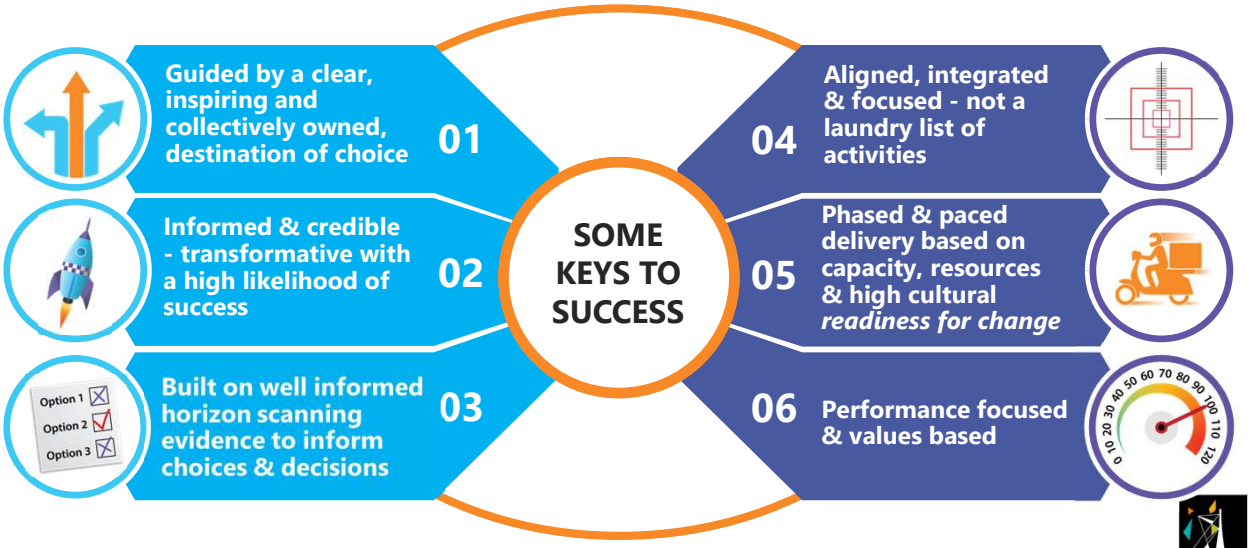
Strategy Development & *Delivery*

- ***"What are the most important factors that need attention to create and successfully implement a strategy in your organisation?"***

35

Strategy Development & *Delivery*



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Which resonate?, which are particularly relevant now? and what would you add?

SOME KEYS TO SUCCESS

- **01** Guided by a clear, inspiring and collectively owned, destination of choice
- **02** Informed & credible - transformative with a high likelihood of success
- **03** Built on well informed horizon scanning evidence to inform choices & decisions
- **04** Aligned, integrated & focused - not a laundry list of activities
- **05** Phased & paced delivery based on capacity, resources & high cultural *readiness for change*
- **06** Performance focused & values based

Distributed individual & team-based accountability

Agile & adaptable to changing circumstances

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LEADING CHANGE
FROM THE 'LAUNCH PAD' PLAN TO 'LIFT OFF'

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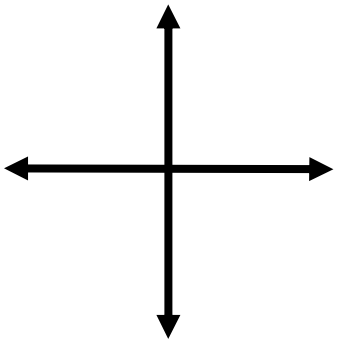
AREAS OF FOCUS

Clarifying and coordinating your collective agenda for 2026 to achieve 'lift-off'

Strategic Focus

Internal Focus



External Focus

Operational Focus

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FROM 'LAUNCH' TO 'LIFT OFF'

AREAS OF FOCUS

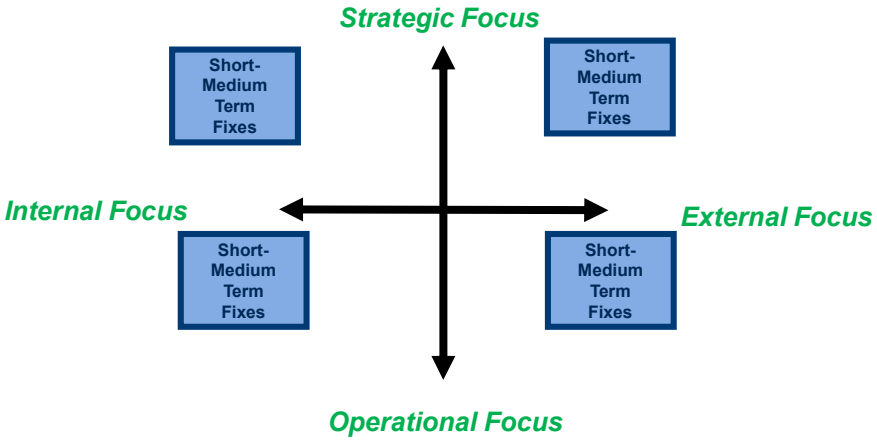
FIXING TECHNICAL THINGS: SHORT-MEDIUM

Short to medium term (3-6 month) more technical led by one or more individuals. These are the foundations for your longer term ambitions and strategic priorities. Involves deploying capabilities that already exist in the organisation.

Short Term Fixes

40

‘FIXING TECHNICAL THINGS’



FROM ‘LAUNCH’ TO ‘LIFT OFF’

AREAS OF FOCUS

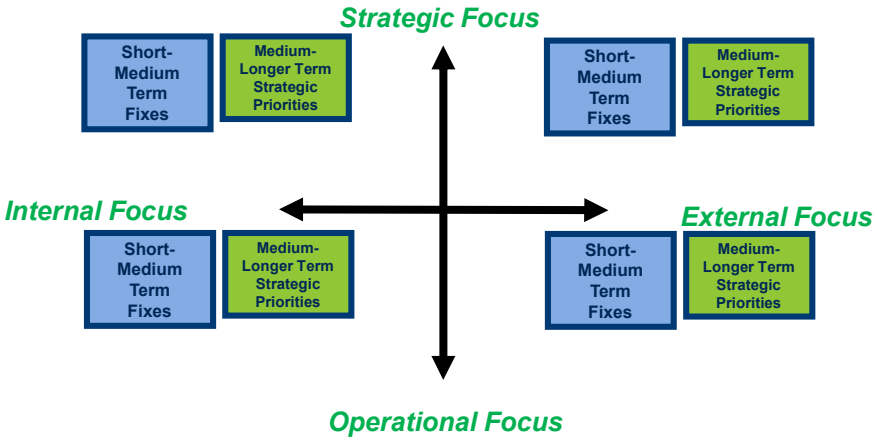
STRATEGIC STUFF: DELIVERING YOUR PROMISES

The areas of strategic importance to which you are committed to delivering as part of your longer term strategy over the medium to long term.

These are often the more adaptive change challenges for which there is no easy nor existing solution within or beyond the organisation. The challenges which will require learning new capabilities and to create new solutions.

Strategic & Adaptive Strategic Priorities

'STRATEGIC & ADAPTIVE PRIORITIES'



FROM 'LAUNCH' TO 'LIFT OFF'

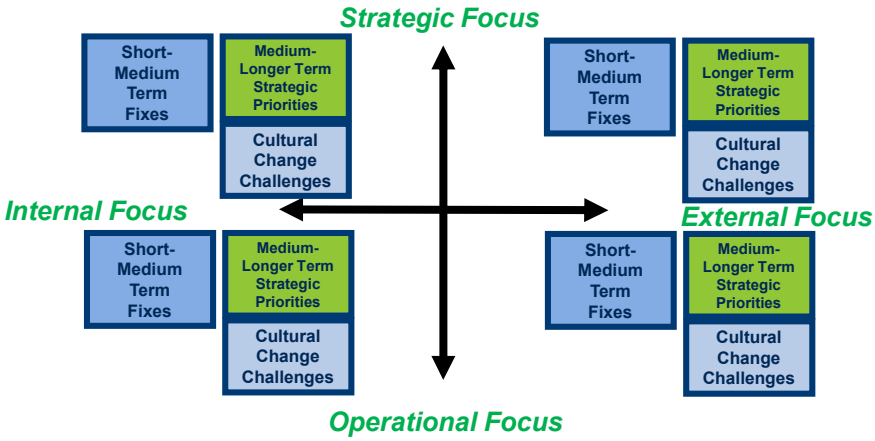
AREAS OF FOCUS

LIVING YOUR VALUES: CULTURAL CHANGE CHALLENGES

The change challenges which will require you to lead with an even more values based approach. Challenges which will help develop new ways of working and will also challenge prevailing cultural norms and behaviours.

Cultural Change Challenges

'VALUES AND CULTURE'



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FROM 'LAUNCH' TO 'LIFT OFF'

AREAS OF FOCUS

STUFF HAPPENS: CRITICAL INCIDENTS

The unexpected, critical incident & risk challenges which will require your urgent attention both individually and as a team. Demands speed of action and offer limited capacity to learn.

What issues are or should be on your critical incident and risk register? How do you build the organisational resilience to respond to such events?

Critical Incident Change Challenges

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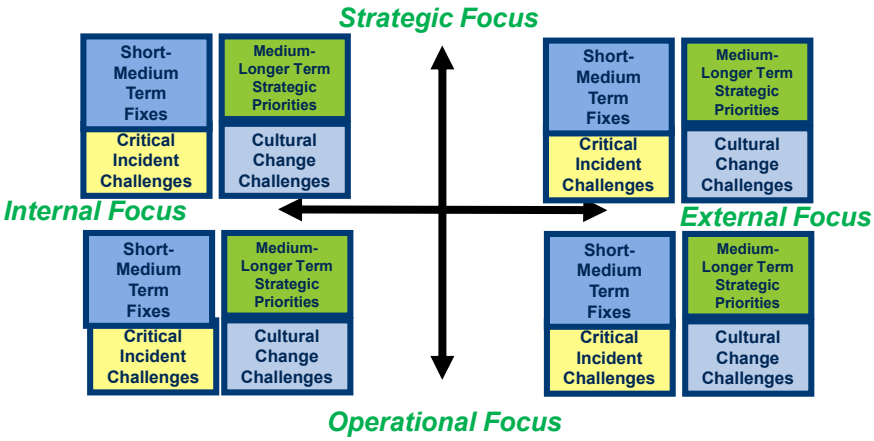
YOUR PORTFOLIO OF OPPORTUNITIES, CHALLENGES & RISKS



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FROM 'LAUNCH' TO 'LIFT OFF'
AREAS OF FOCUS

STOPPING OR REDUCING: CREATING HEADROOM

How can you create some headroom, time, opportunity space by reducing or stopping work in areas which are no longer directly relevant to your new agenda?

Do Less of or Stop

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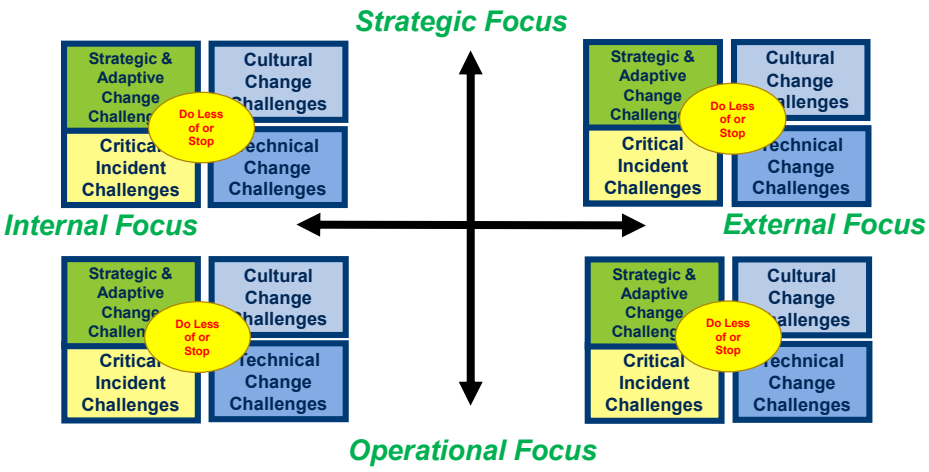
YOUR PORTFOLIO OF OPPORTUNITIES AND CHALLENGES



FROM 'LAUNCH' TO 'LIFT OFF'

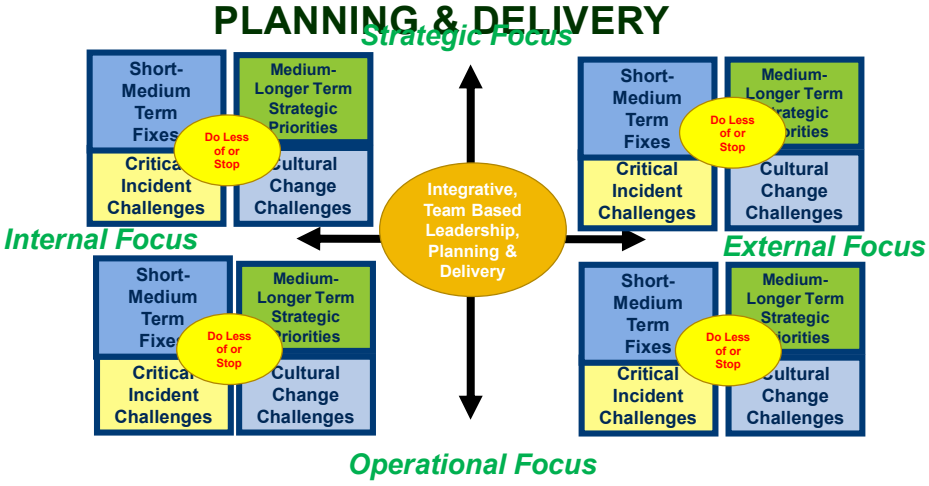
MAKING A DIFFERENCE

MAKING A DIFFERENCE: COMBINED & COORDINATED TEAMWORK & INNOVATION

Your combined agenda, the integration of all your efforts towards the delivery of your overall strategy which collectively have the potential to make a difference.

How do you align your activities to maximise your collective impact through integrative team based leadership, planning and delivery?

MAKING A DIFFERENCE
INTEGRATIVE, TEAM BASED LEADERSHIP, PLANNING & DELIVERY



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ACHIEVING 'LIFT-OFF'
WHAT CHANGE PROJECTS IN EACH AREA

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REFLECTIONS ABOUT THE PROGRAM

- **What has worked well? What has been of most value so far? What have you enjoyed most about the experience?**
- **The one 'take away' idea you will work on/implement?**
- **What will you say to others about the experience when you get home? *Have you been on holiday?....***
- **What would make it even better if ……..?**

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